

# Session 9: Literature Review Techniques

**Kosal Nith**

Cambodia Development Resource Institute

[kosalnith.github.io](https://kosalnith.github.io)

CDRI, September 4, 2026



## By the end of this session, participants should be able to

- ▶ Search for academic and policy literature efficiently.
- ▶ Distinguish relevant sources from merely related sources.
- ▶ Map literature by question, theory, method, evidence and findings.
- ▶ Identify agreements, disagreements and gaps.
- ▶ Synthesize literature into an argument.
- ▶ Connect local evidence to broader economic and social processes.
- ▶ Write a literature review that is analytical rather than descriptive.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

“What papers exist?”

vs.

“What does the literature tell us, what does it not tell us, and why does my research matter?”

## Weak literature review

Smith (2019) found X.

Jones (2020) found Y.

Lee (1978) found Z.

- ▶ The problem is that it is **a list of studies**, not a literature review.
- ▶ We need to ask questions: What do X, Y, and Z collectively tell us?

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# What a strong literature review does

1

## What do we know?

Existing knowledge and findings

2

## How do we know it?

Sources, methods, and evidence used

3

## Where do scholars agree?

Points of consensus in the literature

4

## Where do they disagree?

Contested findings and debates

5

## Why do they disagree?

Roots of the disagreement

6

## What remains unexplained?

Gaps and unanswered questions

7

## What will my research contribute?

Your positioning and contribution

Building the  
Research  
Problem

## What a Literature Review Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap



From Broad  
to  
Specific

## What a Literature Review Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

## **Bad starting point:**

*"I need papers about unemployment."*

## **Better:**

*"How do macroeconomic conditions influence youth employment in Cambodia?"*

## **Even better:**

*"How do changes in aggregate demand, investment and sectoral transformation affect youth employment and skills mismatches in Cambodia?"*

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

**Searching for Literature**

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Turn the question into search concepts

**Research question:** How do macroeconomic conditions influence youth employment in Cambodia?

**Table:** Search Terms by concept

| Concept    | Search terms                            |
|------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Youth      | youth, young workers, young people      |
| Employment | employment, unemployment, labour market |
| Macro      | GDP, growth, demand, investment         |
| Skills     | skills, skills mismatch, human capital  |
| Cambodia   | Cambodia, Cambodian                     |
| Region     | ASEAN, Southeast Asia, Mekong           |

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

- ▶ Instead of searching: Cambodia youth employment
- ▶ Try: "Cambodia" AND ("youth employment" OR "youth unemployment") AND ("economic growth" OR "aggregate demand" OR investment)
- ▶ For skills: "Cambodia" AND ("skills mismatch" OR "skills gap") AND employment
- ▶ For a regional comparison: ("Southeast Asia" OR ASEAN) AND ("skills mismatch" OR "youth employment") AND investment

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

## ▶ L1: Academic literature

- Google Scholar, Scopus, Web of Science, RePEc, JSTOR, EconLit

## ▶ L2: International institutions

- World Bank, IMF, ILO, ADB, UN agencies, and more

## ▶ L3: Regional/local research

- Universities, research institutes, government reports, think-tanks, ...

## ▶ L4: Data

- Database websites or government agencies webs,...

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Don't search for “the answer”

- ▶ A dangerous search strategy:
  - “Does economic growth create jobs?”
  - This encourages confirmation bias.
- ▶ Instead search for competing explanations:
  - economic growth AND employment
  - growthless job creation
  - employment elasticity of growth
  - labour market structural change
  - productivity AND employment
  - aggregate demand AND employment

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

**Searching for Literature**

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

- ▶ One of the most valuable literature-search techniques is by adding words such as:

- 1 debate
- 2 critique
- 3 evidence
- 4 limitations
- 5 contrary
- 6 alternative
- 7 heterogeneity
- 8 controversy
- 9 review
- 10 meta-analysis

- ▶ For example: “human capital” AND “skills mismatch” AND critique
- ▶ It is to find papers that challenge your explanation.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

**Searching for Literature**

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Exercise 1: Search challenges

5 minutes

- ▶ Research question: Why do young people in Cambodia experience difficulties transitioning from education into employment?
- ▶ In pairs:
  - Task 1: Identify 5–7 search terms.
  - Task 2: Create one Boolean search string.
  - Task 3: Identify:
    - 1 academic source
    - 1 international organisation source
    - 1 Cambodia-specific source

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

**Searching for Literature**

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Each source has the different job

**Table:** Types of sources and their utility

| Source                | Useful for               |
|-----------------------|--------------------------|
| Theory paper          | Concepts/mechanisms      |
| Empirical paper       | Evidence                 |
| Review article        | Mapping debates          |
| Working paper         | Emerging research        |
| Policy report         | Institutional evidence   |
| Government statistics | Measurement              |
| Survey                | Micro-level evidence     |
| Historical research   | Context and institutions |

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

Before keeping a paper, ask:

1 Relevance

- Does it answer my research question?

2 Credibility

- Is the source methodologically credible?

3 Contribution

- What does this paper add?

4 Context

- Does the evidence apply to my country/population/period?

5 Usefulness

- What exactly will I use from this paper?

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

- ▶ A paper saying: “Economic growth improves employment.”
- ▶ Ask:
  - Which countries?
  - Which period?
  - Which definition of employment?
  - What method?
  - What mechanism?
  - What assumptions?
  - What alternative explanations?
  - Does the result hold during crises?

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

**Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources**

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

You usually don't need to read every paper

1 **First pass:** 3 minutes → Is this paper worth reading?

- Title
- Abstract
- Introduction
- Conclusion
- Tables/figures

2 **Second pass:** 10-20 minutes

- Theory
- Literature review
- Method
- Key results

3 **Third pass**

- Only for core papers.
- Read deeply and critically.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

A researcher needs all three:

- 1 What does the author say?
  - Description
- 2 Why does the author say it?
  - Explanation
- 3 Do I believe the explanation?
  - Critical evaluation

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

**Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources**

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Build a literature matrix

- ▶ This allows you to compare studies rather than summarize them separately.
- ▶ You can use applications like Zotero, Mendeley, or EndNote
- ▶ Use keywords, tags, and highlights

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

| Author & Date                                                                                                                     | Titles                                                                                             | Question & Hypothesis                                                                                      | Indicators                                                                                            | Theoretical & Conceptual                                                                                                                   | Paradigm & Methodology                                                                         | Context, Setting & Sample                                                                                      | Analysis & Results                                                                                                                                                                | Build Our Framework & Critical                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>CDRI literature – Poverty (Income &amp; Consumption), Rural-Urban Development, Livelihoods, Resilience, Wellbeing, Welfare</b> |                                                                                                    |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                              |
| Lin (2013)                                                                                                                        | Rural Credit during the GFC: 9 Villages, Cambodia                                                  | How did formal/informal credit use change during the crisis, and how was it used?                          | HH characteristics, interest rates, income/weather shocks, loan size & count                          | Credit smooths consumption in crises (Udry 1994, Beale 1995); food prices rose sharply in 2008                                             | Descriptive stats, fixed/random effects regression; PCA asset index                            | CDRI Poverty Dynamics panel, 2001–2011; 700 obs.                                                               | Loan demand rose in the crisis, weather H/Hs borrow less, more dependents → more informal credit                                                                                  | Documents credit-use patterns but offers no policy recommendation                                                                            |
| CDRI (2012)                                                                                                                       | Understanding Poverty Dynamics: 9 Villages, Cambodia                                               | What drives poverty reduction in rural Cambodia?                                                           | Gender, marital status, dependents, education, land size, non-land assets                             | Transient vs. chronic poverty; asset/access gaps; legacy of conflict (national level)                                                      | Multinomial logit, mixed methods (PDS)                                                         | MCPDS data: 1,055 HH (2008); 627 HH panel (2001–2008)                                                          | Income growth necessary but not sufficient; poverty fell 2004–2008; land sales used as coping strategy                                                                            | Comprehensive policy input: CDRI data by village; some data collection inconsistencies                                                       |
| <b>Social capital (Cambodia)</b>                                                                                                  |                                                                                                    |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                              |
| Sen (2012)                                                                                                                        | Social Capital in an Urban and a Rural Community in Cambodia                                       | Examines local realities/potential for social engineering through trust, livelihood, risk, and safety nets | Bonding, bridging, linking social capital                                                             | SC = networks, norms, trust enabling cooperation (Putnam 1983, 1996); World Bank views SC as key to socioeconomic development              | –                                                                                              | Rural village (P'hey Veng) + urban village (Siem Reap); 400 HH (200 each)                                      | Low trust outside the family in both areas; rural bonding SC is kinship-based, informal moneylenders/MFs play a growing role                                                      | Cites Hanlon (1920), Bourdieu (1975), Louny (1977); relies on SC & corruption, social network role, and NISP cash-transfer programmes        |
| Puteki (2006)                                                                                                                     | Traditional Forms of Social Capital in Cambodia and Their Linkage with Local Development Processes | Assesses pagoda associations' potential role in local governance using SC theory                           | –                                                                                                     | SC concept coined late 1980s (Putnam 1993); vertical dimension = hierarchical, unequal power (Krisna 2006)                                 | –                                                                                              | Setum pagoda, Kampong Thom                                                                                     | Trust depends on information availability and formal/informal rules; informal rules enforced via social sanctions/shame (Pye 1999)                                                | Villagers contribute out of religious merit-making beliefs                                                                                   |
| Jahngire (2022)                                                                                                                   | Improving Women's Happiness and Self-Rated Health and Social Capital in Rural Cambodia             | Impact of social capital on women's happiness and self-rated health                                        | Lending money, trust toward family, social network, norms of reciprocity                              | Cognitive vs. structural SC; structural SC = bonding + bridging + linking                                                                  | Ordinal logit regression                                                                       | 203 women, Siem Reap                                                                                           | High income, lending money, family trust, social participation, and wealth positively affect happiness; happiness falls with age, more children, poverty ID                       | –                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Social capital (comparative / international)</b>                                                                               |                                                                                                    |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                              |
| Grootaert (1999)                                                                                                                  | Social Capital, Household Welfare and Poverty in Indonesia                                         | Links between social capital, household welfare, and poverty via local institutions                        | Membership diversity, heterogeneity index, meeting/attendance, decision-making index, membership dues | SC as an input to livelihood production function; builds on Narayan/Pritchett (1997)                                                       | SC index (avg. membership # + decision-making participation); IV methods for reverse causation | Community-level 161 level qual. + quant. interview; 6 associations/44 on average                               | Higher SC households have higher expenditure, more assets, better credit scores; SC effect 4–10% larger than human capital in Tanzania, smaller (but still positive) in Indonesia | Related: "Household Welfare and Social Capital: The Aggregate Model"; "...Disaggregating the SC Index"                                       |
| Fukuyama (2002)                                                                                                                   | Social Capital, Development                                                                        | How the concept of social capital interacts with development, growth, and poverty reduction                | –                                                                                                     | Culnan: SC = ability to work in groups; authoritarian governance thrives on atomization; SC is a critical support for democracy (Sen 1999) | Desk review                                                                                    | –                                                                                                              | Economic policy has limited scope; culture is an important phenomenon of SC; below calls SC "social relationships"                                                                | Theoretical only; discusses families and SC in Cambodia post-Rainey Raung; relies on SC on SC, trust, corruption, and reform                 |
| <b>Household shocks &amp; resilience</b>                                                                                          |                                                                                                    |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                              |
| Phadere et al. (2016)                                                                                                             | Poverty Dynamics, Resilience, Asset Transfers                                                      | Measures the impact of an asset transfer programme on household resilience                                 | –                                                                                                     | Rising climate/economic shocks have pushed anti-poverty programmes toward resilience (Pomeroy/Genevot et al. 2011)                         | Econometric resilience-score model (Cieas & Barnett 2016)                                      | Rural Zambia; 6 waves over 42 months; 111 treatment / 67 control HH; one-time livestock transfer + training    | Transfer programme significantly raises resilience; 26% of treatment HH resilient at baseline vs. 26.6% of control                                                                | Uses Barnett & Conatas (2014) resilience definition; contrasts with our goal of assessing Cambodian HH resilience via income/economic status |
| Groger & Zylberberg (2016)                                                                                                        | Labor Shock                                                                                        | Impact of a disastrous typhoon on poor rural HHs and the role of internal labor migration in recovery      | –                                                                                                     | Crop-damage extent depends on subsequence depth, temperature, plant stage, etc.                                                            | DID in diff. following Dai, Jones & Olan (2014); geophysical satellite data                    | Typhoon Ketsana, Vietnam 2009 (14 provinces, 2.5m affected, 162 killed); 3-wave survey, 2,300 HH, 110 communes | Remittances from long-distance migrants are the main coping strategy; 10% drop in per-capita income, two-thirds from crop losses; short-distance insurance ineffective            | Local (non-migrant) labor doesn't respond to the shock; a good paper overall; see also Stark & Bloom (1985)                                  |

# Exercise 2: Explore Zotero

10 minutes

► In pairs:

- Task 1: Download the Zotero from the Internet
- Task 2: Explore its function
- Task 3: Upload and read the literature in it.
- Task 4: Take notes, add keywords, tags...
- Task 5: Download a Zotero extension in Word
- Task 6: Learn how to cite the reference from Zotero in Word

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

**Mapping the Literature**

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

## Summary.

“Smith finds X.”



## Examples (Synthesis)

“Across the literature, three explanations emerge. The first emphasizes individual skills; the second focuses on labour demand; while a third highlights structural transformation. However, these approaches differ substantially in how they treat macroeconomic conditions and institutions.”

Synthesis = relationships between studies.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

**From Mapping to Synthesis**

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

Don't organize your review only chronologically.

1 Theme

- Skills vs demand vs institution

2 Theory

Neoclassical vs Keynesian vs Structuralist

3 Method

- Microeconometric vs macroeconomic vs qualitative

4 Finding

- Agreement vs disagreement

5 Mechanism

- What causes what?

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

**From Mapping to Synthesis**

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# The “conversation” technique

Imagine the literature is a conversation.

1 Author A:

- Skills explain employment outcomes.

2 Author B:

But skills alone cannot explain weak labour demand.

3 Author C:

- Labour demand depends on investment and structural transformation.

4 Author D:

- Institutions determine how workers and firms respond.

5 Mechanism

- What causes what?

Your job: Become the moderator of the conversation.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

- ▶ Several studies examine skills mismatch in Cambodia. Smith (2019) examines education. Jones (2020) studies firms. Lee (2021) studies employment.
- ▶ The Cambodian literature generally explains skills mismatch through the interaction between education and labour-market demand, but the two sides are not equally developed. Existing studies provide substantial evidence on workers' skills and educational attainment, while fewer studies examine how firms' investment decisions, sectoral transformation and aggregate demand shape the demand for skills. This suggests a gap between micro-level explanations of skills mismatch and macro-structural explanations of employment creation.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# A practical paragraph structure

1

## CLAIM

What does the literature generally tell us?

2

## EVIDENCE

Which studies support this?

3

## CONTRAST

Where do studies disagree?

4

## EXPLANATION

Why might they disagree?

5

## GAP

What remains unexplained?

6

## CONTRIBUTION

What will your research do?

Building  
the  
Argument

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# A practical paragraph structure

The literature generally suggests that [main finding]. However, studies differ in their explanation of this relationship. While [Study/approach A] emphasizes [mechanism], [Study/approach B] argues that [alternative mechanism]. This difference partly reflects their contrasting assumptions about [theory/data/institutions/time/etc.]. Existing research provides important evidence on [what is known], but comparatively less attention has been given to [gap]. This study therefore examines [your research question/contribution].



**Every Review Should End With a Gap**

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

- ☐ What are the major debates?
- ☐ What are the main theories?
- ☐ What evidence exists?
- ☐ Where does the evidence agree?
- ☐ Where does it disagree?
- ☐ What explains the disagreement?
- ☐ What does my research add?

If you cannot answer these: **You probably have a bibliography, not yet a literature review.**

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

**Checklist**

Recap

## SEARCH → MAP → SYNTHESIZE → ARGUE

### ▶ SEARCH

- Find the relevant literature.

### ▶ MAP

- Organize it by theories, questions, methods, evidence and mechanisms.

### ▶ SYNTHESIZE

- Connect studies to one another.

### ▶ ARGUE

- Show what we know, what we don't know, and why your research matters.

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap

# Thank you!

What a Literature Review  
Actually Does

Searching for Literature

Selecting and Evaluating  
Sources

Mapping the Literature

From Mapping to Synthesis

Writing the Literature Review

Checklist

Recap